
New Dog Parent Guide



Everything you need for a happy, confident
start together — from shopping lists to
first-week wisdom, the Maple way.

Before Maple Arrives

The welcome-home shopping list



The essentials

- ☐ Food + water bowls
- ☐ Quality puppy or adult dog food
- ☐ Well-fitted collar + ID tag
- ☐ 4-6 ft leash
- ☐ A crate sized so they can stand, turn around & lie down comfortably (roughly 4-6" longer than their nose-to-tail length)
- ☐ Comfy dog bed
- ☐ Poop bags

The happy extras

- ☐ Chew toys (several textures)
- ☐ Treats for training & bonding
- ☐ Brush suited to their coat
- ☐ Dog-sized nail clippers
- ☐ Puzzle feeder for mental exercise
- ☐ Baby gate for puppy-proofing
- ☐ A blanket that smells like home

Maple's tip

Set up their crate and bed before arrival day, then keep the first day low-key. Skip the dog park — let them settle into the house first.



The First Week



Slow and gentle wins every heart

DAYS
1-2

Quiet arrival

Go straight to the potty spot on arrival. Keep the house calm — no big introductions yet. A crate or bed gives them a safe place to retreat. Skip the dog park and meeting the neighborhood for now — let them bond with your household first.

DAYS
3-4

Gentle routine

Start consistent feeding and potty times. Offer treats and calm, one-on-one greetings with family members, one at a time. Pair their name with something good (a treat, praise) so it becomes a word they associate with attention, not correction.

DAYS
5-7

Exploring home

Let them explore room by room. Begin basic house rules (furniture, off-limit doors) and stay consistent from day one. Try feeding one meal in the crate with the door open — it builds crate comfort without any pressure.

WEEK
2+

Building trust

Start a daily walk and training ritual, introduce other pets slowly, and book a friendly first vet check-up. Look into a local puppy class or leash-walk group once your vet clears them — early positive socializing pays off for years.





Feeding Basics

Happy tummies, healthy bodies

How much & how often

- 🐾 Puppies (under 6 months): 3–4 small meals a day
- 🐾 Adults: 2 meals a day at regular times
- 🐾 Fresh water always available
- 🐾 A quality commercial dog food should be the actual diet, sized to their life stage
- 🐾 Portion size varies hugely by size — follow the feeding chart on your food's packaging, based on your dog's weight, and split the total into 2 meals a day
- 🐾 Switch foods gradually over 7–10 days to avoid tummy upsets

Treats (a few times a week, not daily)

- 🐾 Baby carrots or carrot slices — a satisfying low-calorie crunch
- 🐾 Green beans (plain, not seasoned) — many dogs love them raw or steamed
- 🐾 Apple slices, seeds and core removed
- 🐾 Blueberries — a handful makes a great training treat
- 🐾 Plain canned pumpkin (not pie filling) in small spoonfuls
- 🐾 Treats overall: no more than about 10% of daily calories

Never feed your dog

- 🐾 Onions, garlic, chives & leeks
- 🐾 Chocolate, coffee & anything caffeinated
- 🐾 Grapes & raisins
- 🐾 Alcohol & raw dough
- 🐾 Xylitol (in sugar-free gum & candy)
- 🐾 Macadamia nuts
- 🐾 Cooked bones & anything wider than they should swallow whole

If something risky gets eaten

Call your vet or the ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center right away:

(888) 426-4435 — available 24/7



A Dog-Safe Home

Curiosity-proofing 101



Plants to keep far away

- 🐾 Sago palm — every part is toxic, especially the seeds
- 🐾 Azalea & rhododendron
- 🐾 Autumn crocus & cyclamen
- 🐾 Tulip & daffodil bulbs (the bulb is the most toxic part)

Safe greenery instead

- 🐾 Spider plant
- 🐾 Boston fern
- 🐾 Areca palm
- 🐾 Rosemary (in moderation)
- 🐾 Parlor palm
- 🐾 Friendship plant

Around the house

- 🐾 Secure trash cans — a curious nose finds everything
- 🐾 Block stairs with a baby gate until a puppy is steadier on their feet
- 🐾 Tuck away cords, socks & small chewable objects
- 🐾 Keep the toilet lid down (yes, really — dogs drink from it)
- 🐾 Check fence lines and gaps for escape routes before floor/yard time



Cleaning & Care

A simple rhythm keeps everyone healthy



Every day

- 🐾 Wash food & water bowls, or refill with fresh water
- 🐾 Pick up waste on walks immediately, and clear the yard daily

Every week

- 🐾 Wash bedding (more often if muddy or smelly)
- 🐾 Brush a short-coated dog at least once — several times a week to daily for long or double coats
- 🐾 Wipe down toys, especially chew toys and anything that's been outside

Every month

- 🐾 Check and clean ears with a vet-approved solution (more often if prone to infections)
- 🐾 Bathe most dogs every 4-6 weeks — over-bathing strips natural coat oils

Good to know

- 🐾 Nail trims: every 3-4 weeks, or when you hear them clicking on the floor
- 🐾 Teeth: brushing 2-3 times a week with dog-specific toothpaste — never human toothpaste, which can contain xylitol or fluoride



Health & Vet Care

A little routine goes a long way



The usual schedule

- 🐾 First check-up within the first week of coming home
- 🐾 Puppies: core vaccine visits roughly every 3–4 weeks until ~16 weeks old
- 🐾 Adults: a wellness visit once a year
- 🐾 Seniors (7+ years): twice-yearly check-ups are ideal
- 🐾 Ask your vet about heartworm prevention, spay/neuter & microchipping

Call the vet if you notice

- ♥ Not eating or drinking for 24 hours
- ♥ Repeated vomiting or diarrhea
- ♥ A swollen, hard belly with unproductive retching — seek care immediately
- ♥ Limping, excessive drinking/urinating, or sudden behavior changes
- ♥ Coughing, labored breathing, or crying when touched

My dog's vet info

Clinic: _____

Phone: _____

Emergency clinic: _____

Phone: _____



Cool Dog Facts

A little trivia to impress your friends



1

A dog's nose print is completely unique, just like a human fingerprint.

2

A dog's sense of smell is estimated to be 10,000 to 100,000 times more sensitive than a human's.

3

The average dog can learn over 165 words, and some exceptionally clever dogs learn 1,000+.

4

Puppies are born completely deaf and blind, relying entirely on touch and smell at first.

5

Dogs have a third eyelid, called a haw, that helps protect and moisten the eye.

6

A dog's average body temperature (101-102.5°F) runs noticeably warmer than a human's.

7

Curling into a ball to sleep is an instinct inherited from wild ancestors — it conserves body heat and protects vital organs.

8

Some sighthound breeds, like Greyhounds, can run up to 45 mph.

9

Some dogs can be trained to detect certain human health conditions, like low blood sugar or specific cancers, by scent alone.

10

A dog's nose is so sensitive it can detect some scents diluted to parts per trillion — often compared to smelling a teaspoon of sugar in two Olympic-sized pools.

